of contemporary times has provided the basis for change beyond that binary. It is not merely a platitude to state that this is now an era of greater cooperation. New activities and energies emerged from the freedom of nations to be taken forward by comparative advantage. In due course, their political importance increased in world affairs. In doing so, countries transcended their earlier predicament and became factors of influence. Large ones, in particular, regained their natural weight and salience in the calculations of others. Their choices and actions started to determine not only their own prospects but also those of others. This could be from a set of capabilities, a reservoir of resources, the quality of talent, the importance of location or even national will and leadership.

It is the entirety of this matrix that is shaping the rise of India. As our nation completes 75 years of independence, Indians should examine their prospects against a global context that has been equally transformational. The world undoubtedly offers vastly more opportunities, but that is also embedded with new responsibilities. India matters because these cannot be separated, and it counts on both scores.

While size and population are obvious indices of a nation’s potential, neither is a self-fulfilling criterion by itself. Our own past history is proof of that assertion. There are others, too, whose political standing has been below par despite these attributes. And, in contrast, there are much smaller nations that have punched way above their weight. The core of global rebalancing has been the revival of China, India and some others in the Global South that have made their long-standing characteristics count more through national revival. A key factor is the pace and nature of development, including the enhancement of human resource quality.

In this respect, recent happenings are a source of hope for India. There is, after 2014, a holistic commitment to achieving social development goals through dedicated campaigns covering every segment. They include better health and immunization, reducing gender gaps, expanding educational access and coverage, promoting skills to fostering talent and innovation, making it easier to do business and creating greater employment opportunities. The resulting inclusive growth will naturally contribute to strengthening capabilities and expanding the marketplace. But just as notable will be its impact on the global workplace, and this really matters for the world.